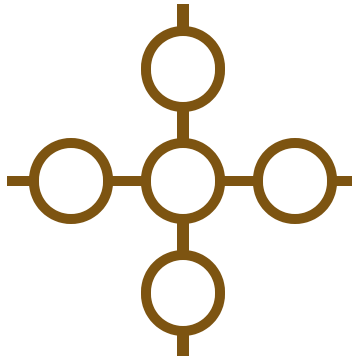


CITIPOINTE CHURCH



Multiply

disciples making disciples

GROUP MEMBER'S COMPANION

Volume One · Foundations and the Promise

This booklet accompanies *Multiply: Disciples Making Disciples* by Francis Chan with Mark Beuving (David C Cook, 2012). The book is optional here. Each session carries its own summary and the Scripture it works from, so you can come having read one page and take part fully.

What follows is only the passages we will read together and the questions we will discuss, so that you can come having already thought about them. Scripture quotations are from the ESV® Bible, copyright © 2001 by Crossway. Used by permission. All rights reserved.

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SEASON

Season One: Foundations and the Promise

BIG IDEA

Following Jesus means becoming like Him in the company of His people, and the story we have joined opens with a good world lost and a promise made.

Twelve weeks. The first nine build the foundation: what a disciple is, what it means to live as the church, and how to read the Bible. The last three open the Old Testament story, from creation through the fall to the promise God makes to Abraham.

Read the session in brief on the first page of each session, and read the Scripture listed with it. Ten minutes is enough. Nobody is expected to have read the book, and answering the questions honestly for yourself matters more than any preparation.

PART

Part I: Living as a Disciple Maker

BIG IDEA

A disciple becomes like Jesus and makes more disciples.
There is no third option.

Three sessions on what a disciple is and what we have been asked to do. Chan's argument here is that following Jesus costs everything, and that every follower is commissioned to make more followers. Everything later in the book rests on these three.

What Is a Disciple?

Part I, Session 1

BIG IDEA

A disciple is someone who follows Jesus closely enough to end up like Him, and that costs everything.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- A disciple is an apprentice, and an apprentice ends up like his teacher (Luke 6:40).
 - So a Christian who is not becoming like Christ is a contradiction, not a category.
 - Repent means turn. It is an action, not an opinion.
 - Salvation is grace through faith; part of repenting is giving up the idea that you contribute anything.
 - Lord is a title meaning master and owner, so confessing Him means you do not write your own job description.
 - It is not joyless duty: it comes down to love of God and neighbor, and obedience is what love looks like.
 - Luke 14 asks you to count the cost before you start.
-

READ BEFORE WE MEET

Luke 6:40 and Luke 14:25 to 33. Read Luke 14 slowly and all the way through, including the two parables and the closing line about renouncing all that you have.

“A disciple is not above his teacher, but everyone when he is fully trained will be like his teacher” (Luke 6:40).

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

1. Luke 6:40 says a fully trained disciple becomes like his teacher. If that is the definition, what should be visibly true of someone who has followed Jesus for ten years?
2. Compare the answers we gave earlier about what a Christian is with what Jesus says in Luke 14. Where is the gap?
3. Jesus tells two stories about counting the cost, a builder and a king. Why would He make it harder to follow Him rather than easier? What does that tell you about what He is after?
4. Chan argues you cannot be a Christian without becoming like Christ. Is there any way to hold that without ending up in works righteousness? Where does grace sit in this?
5. Where in your life is there a gap between what you say you believe and how you actually live? Be specific with yourself. You do not have to say it out loud yet.
6. Jesus summed up the law as love of God and love of neighbor. If love is the test, how would you know if you were failing it?

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

Name one specific thing this week that would look different if Luke 14 were true of you. One thing, this week, concrete enough that you could report on it next time.

Then sit with the harder question. Is there anyone in your life you would consider walking through this book with?

My one thing this week

The Command to Make Disciples

Part I, Session 2

BIG IDEA

The Great Commission was given to every believer rather than to professionals, and it rests on Christ's authority rather than on your qualifications.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- The disciples expected Jesus to fix the world. Instead He handed them the job and ascended.
 - Matthew 28 is read as addressed to pastors and missionaries. It was addressed to them, and to us.
 - We have built a culture where paid ministers do ministry and everyone else attends and leaves fed.
 - Disciple making is not a program to complete. A disciple is by definition a disciple maker.
 - The commission has three parts: go, baptize, teach obedience.
 - Baptism was a public declaration of allegiance that marked people for hostility.
 - Leaders equip; every member does the ministry (Ephesians 4). The usual excuses have no exception clause.
-

READ BEFORE WE MEET

Matthew 28:16 to 20. Read the whole scene, including verse 17 and the detail that some doubted.

“All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age” (Matthew 28:18 to 20).

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

1. Verse 17 says some doubted, and Jesus commissioned them anyway. What does that do to the idea that you have to have it together before God uses you?
2. The command is bracketed by two statements about Jesus: all authority is His, and He is with us always. Why does the command need those brackets? What happens to disciple making when we forget them?
3. “Teaching them to observe all that I have commanded.” Not teaching them to know. What is the difference, and which one does most church teaching actually aim at?
4. Chan says discipleship is more than a program. What is the difference between a program and a relationship, in practice? Which has your experience of church mostly been?
5. If every believer is commissioned, why do so few Christians make disciples? Name the real reasons, not the polite ones.
6. Who is one person in your life who is not far from you and might say yes to walking through this together?

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

Write down two or three names of people you could invest in. This is not a commitment yet, just names on paper. Pray over the list this week.

My one thing this week

The Heart of a Disciple Maker

Part I, Session 3

BIG IDEA

God weighs the motive behind the ministry, and teaching without love does damage rather than good.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- Wrong motives do not make ministry neutral. They can make it harmful.
 - The Pharisees were constantly ministering and are the villains of the Gospels.
 - God looks at the heart, not the outward appearance (1 Samuel 16:7).
 - To the reluctant: God wants ministry done from joy, not obligation.
 - To the eager: teaching is dangerous. James 3 on the tongue is a warning, not a flourish.
 - Every gift and all knowledge amount to nothing without love (1 Corinthians 13).
 - Teaching what you do not practice is hypocrisy, and Hebrews 13:7 assumes a life open to examination.
 - You do not need to be perfect to start. You do need to have counted the cost.
-

READ BEFORE WE MEET

James 3:1 to 12, then 1 Corinthians 13:1 to 3. Read them back to back. The pairing is the point: teaching is dangerous, and gifting without love is nothing.

“For the LORD sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart” (1 Samuel 16:7).

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

1. Why would God judge teachers more strictly? What is actually at stake when someone teaches badly?
2. 1 Corinthians 13 says you can have every gift and be nothing without love. What does that mean for someone who is good at explaining the Bible but hard to be around?
3. Chan asks why you want to make disciples. Sit with that. What are the wrong reasons, and which of them do you recognize in yourself?
4. Jesus said of the Pharisees that they preach but do not practice, and that they do their deeds to be seen. What are the modern forms of that? Where does it show up in church culture you have been part of?
5. Hebrews 13:7 says to consider the outcome of their way of life and imitate their faith. That assumes leaders whose lives can be watched. What does that require of a leader, practically?
6. 1 Corinthians 8:1 says knowledge puffs up but love builds up. Have you seen that happen? What did it look like?

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

Name one area where your life does not yet match what you would teach. Say it to the group or to one other person. Then decide what one step of repentance looks like this week.

My one thing this week

PART

Part II: Living as the Church

BIG IDEA

You cannot follow Jesus alone, and the congregation God has placed you in is His strategy for reaching the world.

Three sessions moving outward: life in the church, the local church, the global church. Chan argues that the church is neither optional nor a service you attend. If church has hurt you in the past, this part may be uncomfortable, and it is worth saying so out loud when we meet.

Life in the Church

Part II, Session 1

BIG IDEA

Discipleship happens inside a body whose members carry one another's burdens and aim at the heart rather than at the behavior.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- The West admires people who go it alone. You cannot follow Jesus that way.
- The New Testament is full of one another commands, and it is impossible to one another yourself.
- Of roughly 114 New Testament uses of church, at least ninety mean a specific local gathering.
- People avoid commitment for real reasons: self sufficiency, fear of accountability, church hopping, past hurt.
- Ministry is not intimidating once you see it as serving the people already around you (Galatians 6:1 to 2).
- We treat symptoms. Manage an angry man's triggers and nothing changes, because it comes from the heart (Mark 7).
- Only God changes hearts, through His Spirit, His Word and prayer (Ezekiel 36:26 to 27).
- A body grows only when each part works; an inactive member makes the rest compensate.

READ BEFORE WE MEET

Acts 2:42 to 47, then Hebrews 10:24 to 25.

“And let us consider how to stir up one another to love and good works, not neglecting to meet together, as is the habit of some, but encouraging one another, and all the more as you see the Day drawing near” (Hebrews 10:24 to 25).

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

1. Acts 2 describes a group who devoted themselves to teaching, fellowship, breaking bread, and prayer, and who shared possessions. Which of those four is weakest in your experience of church? Why?
2. Hebrews says to consider how to stir up one another. That is deliberate, planned effort. What would it look like to actually plan how to provoke someone toward love this month?
3. Chan pushes for getting beneath the surface. What keeps us at the surface with each other? Name the actual mechanisms, not just “we’re busy.”
4. James 5:16 says confess your sins to one another. Why do we almost never do this? What would have to be true of a group for that to be safe?
5. Ephesians 4 says leaders equip the saints for the work of ministry. If that is the design, what has gone wrong when the paid staff do the ministry and everyone else watches?
6. What is one gift or capacity you have that the body is not currently getting from you?

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

Choose one specific act of service or encouragement toward someone in the church this week. Not necessarily someone in this group, someone in the wider church.

My one thing this week

The Local Church

Part II, Session 2

BIG IDEA

The world is meant to recognize Jesus by the visible love and unity of His people, not by the quality of our arguments.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- Everything about devotion to one another still stands, and it is not the point.
- An inwardly focused church is unhealthy, dying, and biblically not a church at all.
- We are a lighthouse rather than a bomb shelter: not hiding from trouble but guiding others through it.
- The world identifies disciples by love, not by doctrine or morality (John 13:34 to 35).
- Jesus prayed for unity so the world would believe (John 17). We assume arguments will convince; He said unity would.
- That prayer assumes our life together is visible. Hidden church life proves nothing to anyone.
- 1 Peter 3 assumes we suffer unjustly and respond with such hope that people ask. Mostly nobody asks.
- Israel was a kingdom of priests; the church now carries that calling (1 Peter 2:9).

READ BEFORE WE MEET

John 13:34 to 35, then John 17:20 to 23, then Matthew 5:14 to 16.

“A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another. By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another” (John 13:34 to 35).

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

1. Jesus says the world will identify His disciples by their love for one another. Not by doctrine, not by morality, by love. Why that? And is that how we are actually identified?
2. In John 17 Jesus prays for unity so that the world may believe. What is the connection between a united church and a believing world?
3. Matthew 5 says let your light shine before others so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father. How do you do good visibly without doing it to be seen, which Jesus condemns in Matthew 6?
4. 1 Peter 2:9 calls the church a royal priesthood. What does a priest do, and what does it mean that the whole congregation is one?
5. Chan says your local church matters. If your congregation disappeared tomorrow, would the neighborhood notice? What would be missing?
6. What is one thing your church does well that the neighborhood can actually see? What is one thing it does not?

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

We will decide together on one thing this group can do for the neighborhood in the next month, and put a date on it. Come with an idea.

My one thing this week

The Global Church

Part II, Session 3

BIG IDEA

God promised from the beginning to bless every family of the earth, and nobody can call on a Savior they have never heard of.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- Reaching everyone in your town still would not finish the mission.
 - Genesis 3:15 promises a rescuer for the human race, not for one ethnic group.
 - Genesis 12 narrows to one family precisely so all families of the earth are blessed.
 - Paul was a missionary before he was a theologian, ambitious to preach where Christ was not named.
 - Romans 10 gives the chain: calling needs believing, believing needs hearing, hearing needs preaching, preaching needs sending.
 - Many groups still have no access to the gospel. The assumption that anyone interested can find it is false.
 - Everyone is involved; not everyone goes. Go, send, pray, learn are all real responses.
-

READ BEFORE WE MEET

Genesis 12:1 to 3, then Romans 10:12 to 15, then Revelation 7:9 to 10. Read them in that order. Together they are the whole arc of the Bible's missionary purpose.

*“How then will they call on him in whom they have not believed?
And how are they to believe in him of whom they have never
heard? And how are they to hear without someone preaching?
And how are they to preach unless they are sent?” (Romans 10:14
to 15).*

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

1. God’s promise to Abraham was that all the families of the earth would be blessed through him. How does that shape how you read the rest of the Old Testament?
2. Romans 10 works backward: calling, believing, hearing, preaching, sending. Which link in that chain is your church strongest at? Which is weakest?
3. Revelation 7 shows a multitude from every nation, tribe, people, and language. Not one culture absorbed into another, all of them present. What does that say about God’s view of the nations?
4. Matthew 24:14 ties the gospel reaching all nations to the end coming. What do you do with that? How should it affect urgency?
5. Chan asks about places where Christ has not been named. Do you know where those places are? Should you?
6. Is there any reason you should not go? Ask it seriously. Not everyone should, but most people have never actually asked.

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

Take one unreached people group, learn about them this month, and pray for them. You will report back to the group in a few weeks.

And ask yourself honestly whether God might be calling you to go.

My one thing this week

PART

Part III: How to Study the Bible

BIG IDEA

Scripture is God speaking, so it is read prayerfully, obediently and carefully, or it is misread.

Three sessions on handling Scripture: why we study it, how to study it prayerfully and obediently, and how to study it carefully. This is the most practical part of the book, and it is what will equip you to lead someone else later.

Why Study the Bible?

Part III, Session 1

BIG IDEA

Why you open the Bible determines what it does to you, and knowledge pursued for its own sake puffs up.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- Disciple making means teaching obedience, so we have to know what Jesus commanded.
 - We are not at a disadvantage for having missed Jesus in person. It was written down.
 - Three wrong motives: guilt, which breeds legalism and quotas; status; and hunting for teaching material.
 - God gave the Bible to teach us about Himself, about ourselves and the world, and to make us godly.
 - Also to build relationship with Him, to exalt Jesus, and to prepare us for mission.
 - We think we read the Bible. In fact it reads us (Hebrews 4:12).
 - Approach it as a student rather than searching for agreement with what you already hold.
 - Knowledge puffs up. Bible study has produced some of the most arrogant people alive.
-

READ BEFORE WE MEET

2 Timothy 3:16 to 17, then 1 Peter 2:1 to 3.

“All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work” (2 Timothy 3:16 to 17).

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

1. Paul lists four uses: teaching, reproof, correction, training in righteousness. Which of those do you actually let the Bible do to you? Which do you skip?
2. Verse 17 gives the purpose: complete, equipped for every good work. Equipped for what? Notice the aim is not knowledge but readiness to act.
3. 1 Peter says to long for the pure spiritual milk like newborn infants. What does spiritual hunger feel like, and what kills it?
4. Chan names wrong motives for Bible study: guilt, status, gathering teaching material. Which of those has driven you? Be specific.
5. 1 Corinthians 8:1 says knowledge puffs up. How do you study seriously without becoming that person?
6. If the Bible’s purpose includes exalting Jesus and preparing us for mission, how would that change what you look for when you open it?

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

Set a Bible reading plan for the next month: what you will read, when, and where. Be specific enough that you could fail at it. You will say it out loud to the group.

My one thing this week

Studying the Bible Prayerfully and Obediently

Part III, Session 2

BIG IDEA

You cannot understand Scripture without the Holy Spirit, and you have not finished reading until you have obeyed.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- People handle Scripture as rulebook, character gallery, mystical oracle, or academic object. Most of us cycle through all four.
- Read it devotionally, meaning devoted. Psalm 119 is 176 verses of delight in God's word.
- We talk about praying and reading. We rarely pray while reading.
- Enough exegesis, Greek and commentaries will not do it. That mentality leaves no room for the Spirit.
- You cannot understand Scripture without the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 2:14).
- Dependence on revelation is not a result of the fall; Adam needed it before there was any sin.
- Read expecting to obey. Study that never becomes action is misuse.
- Read with faith: the promises are as trustworthy as the God who makes them.

READ BEFORE WE MEET

1 Corinthians 2:9 to 14, then James 1:22 to 25.

“The natural person does not accept the things of the Spirit of God, for they are folly to him, and he is not able to understand them because they are spiritually discerned” (1 Corinthians 2:14).

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

1. Paul says the natural person cannot understand the things of the Spirit. What does that mean for how you approach a passage? What does it mean for how you talk to a friend who finds the Bible foolish?
2. If understanding Scripture depends on the Spirit, what does that look like practically when you sit down to read? What would change about the first two minutes?
3. James says the person who hears without doing is like someone who looks in a mirror and forgets what he looks like. What is it about hearing without doing that produces forgetting?
4. Chan argues we should read expecting to obey. How would your reading change if you assumed every passage required a response?
5. Have you ever avoided a part of the Bible because you knew what it would ask of you? Which part?
6. James 1:26 and 27 gives a test of real religion: bridled tongue, care for widows and orphans, unstained by the world. How does that test land on you?

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

Take the passage you are reading this week and write down one question: what does this ask me to do? Then do it, and be ready to say how it went.

My one thing this week

Studying Logically

Part III, Session 3

BIG IDEA

A passage has one meaning and many applications, and context is what stops you inventing both.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- Careful work does not guarantee right results, and it is still commanded (2 Timothy 2:15).
- We all misread some passages. If we did not, we would agree on every point of doctrine.
- Context first. Think apple rather than orange: a verse is a bite from a whole, not a detached segment.
- A passage has one meaning and many applications. Reverse that and misinterpretation stops existing.
- Find the plain meaning. Luke 12:33 is the test case we reflexively explain away.
- If the literal sense makes sense, seek no other sense, allowing for metaphor, parable and poetry.
- Historical context matters: Jeremiah 29:11 was written to exiles, not printed for coffee mugs.
- The biggest danger is your own baggage, cultural and personal.

READ BEFORE WE MEET

2 Timothy 2:15, then read your practice passage twice: once alone, then with the surrounding paragraph.

“Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who has no need to be ashamed, rightly handling the word of truth” (2 Timothy 2:15).

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

Spend most of this block on the practice passage rather than on the questions in order.

1. Read the practice verse by itself. What do people usually take it to mean?
2. Now read the paragraph around it. What is the writer actually talking about? What changes?
3. Is the meaning smaller or larger than the popular use? For Philippians 4:13, most groups find it is larger, and harder.
4. Chan distinguishes interpretation from application. A passage has one meaning and many applications. Why does that order matter? What goes wrong when we reverse it?
5. What is the difference between taking the Bible literally and taking it woodenly? Think of a psalm, a parable, a proverb, a letter. Do you read them the same way?
6. Take one more passage cold and work it together: read the context, state the plain meaning, then ask what it asks of us.

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

Take a passage this week and write three lines on it: what it says, what it means, what it asks of you. Bring it next time.

My one thing this week

PART

Part IV: Understanding the Old Testament

BIG IDEA

The Old Testament is one story of God making a people for Himself and coming to dwell with them, and every thread in it is left unfinished until Jesus.

Nine sessions tracing the storyline from creation to exile. This is the longest part and the one where groups most often lose momentum, so say up front that it is nine weeks and put an end date on the calendar.

Creation

Part IV, Session 1

BIG IDEA

God made a good world and made humanity in His own image to reflect His rule over it.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- The Bible tells one true story, and it is unfinished. You have a part in it.
 - Genesis never answers our philosophical questions about God. It tells us what He did: He created.
 - God is the only character in Genesis 1 and the only eternal one, so nothing compares with Him.
 - This world is His because He spoke it into being. Our authority over it is delegated, not owned.
 - Image of God: rather than pin it to one faculty, read it as reflecting Him. Jesus does so perfectly (Colossians 1:15).
 - Kings set up images of themselves to announce who ruled. Humans standing in creation do the same.
 - Genesis 2 is more intimate: God forms, breathes, speaks. Adam needed revelation even before sin.
 - Work exists before the fall. The curse made it frustrating; it did not invent it.
-

READ BEFORE WE MEET

Genesis 1:26 to 28 and Genesis 2:15.

*“Then God said, ‘Let us make man in our image, after our likeness. And let them have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the heavens and over the livestock and over all the earth and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth’”
(Genesis 1:26).*

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

1. Before anything else, Genesis 1 tells us about God. What is He like, based only on this chapter?
2. What does it mean to be made in God’s image? What is it about humans that is not true of anything else God made?
3. Humanity is given dominion and put in the garden to work it and keep it. Work exists before the fall. What does that do to the idea that work is a curse?
4. If every human bears God’s image, what follows for how you treat the person you find hardest to be around?
5. Colossians 1:15 calls Jesus the image of the invisible God. How does that connect back to Genesis 1?
6. Psalm 8 marvels that God is mindful of man. When did you last actually feel that?

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

Identify one person you habitually treat as less than an image bearer, and one concrete thing you will do about it this week.

My one thing this week

The Fall

Part IV, Session 2

BIG IDEA

Sin is a declaration of independence from God, and it broke every relationship humanity had.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- You felt the results of the fall today. Everyone senses the world is not as it should be.
 - The serpent points at the one restriction so Eve feels deprived, then promises she will be like God.
 - The garden was already full of good things. What he offered was goodness apart from God.
 - He is subtle, and he is a creature. Be wary of his lies without fearing his power.
 - Sin is always a declaration of autonomy: the right to decide good and evil for yourself.
 - They had God's word and let another voice outrank it.
 - The damage is total: hiding, shame, exile, blame, pain, cursed ground, and death.
 - Genesis 4 to 11 makes it worse, and Genesis 3:15 already promises a rescuer.
-

READ BEFORE WE MEET

Genesis 3, the whole chapter. It is short, and it works best read as a story.

“I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel” (Genesis 3:15).

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

1. Trace how the serpent works in verses 1 to 5. What is the sequence? Where do you recognize it in your own temptations?
2. The first consequence is hiding. Why is shame the immediate result rather than punishment?
3. God curses the serpent and the ground but not the man and woman directly. What do you make of that?
4. Genesis 3:15 is the first promise of a rescuer, spoken in the middle of a curse. What does it tell you about God that judgment and promise arrive in the same breath?
5. Romans 8:20 to 21 says creation itself was subjected to futility and will be set free. What in the world around you looks like creation groaning?
6. From Cain to Babel the situation gets worse, not better. Why does the Bible bother telling us that stretch of the story?

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

Where is the pattern of Genesis 3 running in your life right now? The questioning of God's goodness, the grasping, the hiding. Name it to one other person.

My one thing this week

God's Covenant with Abraham

Part IV, Session 3

BIG IDEA

God chose one man in order to bless every nation, and bound Himself to the promise regardless of what Abraham's descendants would do.

THE SESSION IN BRIEF

Nobody needs to have read anything before tonight. This is the argument in short — read it on your own or have it read aloud when the group sits down.

- A rhythm has emerged: people sin, they face the consequences, God redeems.
- After scattering the nations at Babel, God immediately promises to bless all of them.
- The covenant runs through Genesis 12, 15 and 17. Land is central to it.
- Covenant partners walked between severed animals, invoking that fate on themselves. God walked alone.
- So the covenant holds regardless of what Abraham's descendants do.
- The greatest blessing God offers is Himself: I will be your God and you will be my people.
- Galatians 3 says that in you all the nations will be blessed was the gospel preached in advance.
- God's blessings are to be shared, not hoarded. Abraham believed, and it was counted as righteousness.

READ BEFORE WE MEET

Genesis 12:1 to 9, then Genesis 15:1 to 21. Read the covenant ceremony in 15:9 to 17 slowly. It is strange, and the strangeness is the point.

“Go from your country and your kindred and your father’s house to the land that I will show you. And I will make of you a great nation, and I will bless you and make your name great, so that you will be a blessing. I will bless those who bless you, and him who dishonors you I will curse, and in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed” (Genesis 12:1 to 3).

QUESTIONS WE WILL DISCUSS

1. God tells Abram to leave without telling him the destination. What kind of faith does that require? Where has God asked something like that of you?
2. The promise ends with all the families of the earth being blessed. Why does the whole world show up in a promise to one man?
3. In Genesis 15 the animals are cut in half and God alone passes between the pieces while Abram sleeps. In that culture both parties walked the path. What is God saying by walking it alone?
4. Genesis 15:6 says Abram believed the LORD and it was counted to him as righteousness. Paul builds his whole argument for justification by faith on that verse. Why does it matter that this comes centuries before the law?
5. Galatians 3:7 to 9 says those of faith are sons of Abraham. What does that make you, in this story?
6. Jesus said Abraham rejoiced to see His day. What do you think Abraham saw?

TAKING IT INTO THE WEEK

Where is God asking you to move without showing you the destination? Name it, then name the next step you can actually take this week.

My one thing this week
